

Production Setup Guide

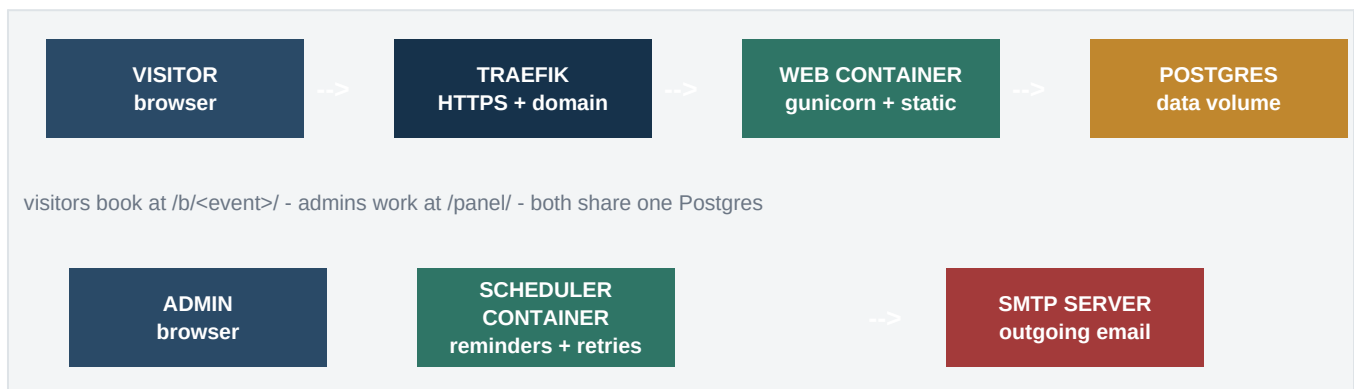
Deploy TravelDoor Connect on Dokploy and switch on real email

Covers: push code -> Dokploy deploy -> first login -> SMTP mail -> go-live checks

TravelDoor Connect | generated 05 Sep 2026 | internal documentation

WHAT YOU ARE DEPLOYING

Two containers from one image, plus a managed PostgreSQL and your company mailbox:



web runs migrations, collects static files and serves the app (gunicorn + WhiteNoise). **scheduler** sends reminder emails and retries failed deliveries every 30 seconds. TLS certificates, domain routing and the database are provided by Dokploy.

BEFORE YOU START

Everything below assumes the code is final and committed. Run the test suite first: `python manage.py test` (160 tests must pass), then continue.

DEPLOY ON DOKPLOY - 6 STEPS

1 Commit and push the code

Every uncommitted file (especially migrations) must be in Git, or the production database schema will not match the code.

```
git add -A
git commit -m "Prepare for production deploy"
git push origin main
```

2 Point DNS at the server

In your domain's DNS panel add an **A record** (or CNAME) for e.g. **booking.yourcompany.com** pointing at the Dokploy server IP. If a wildcard *.yourcompany.com already points there, skip this step.

3 Create the database

Dokploy -> your project -> **Databases** -> **PostgreSQL** -> **Create**. Wait for it to become healthy. Open its **Connection** tab and copy the **Internal Connection URL** - you will paste it as DATABASE_URL in step 4.

4 Create the app + set environment variables

Dokploy -> **Create** -> **Docker Compose**, source **Git**, pick the repository, compose file **docker-compose.dokploy.yml**. Then open **Environment** and add exactly these (raw values, no quotes, no < > brackets):

Variable	Value	Why it matters
DATABASE_URL	internal Postgres URL from step 3	the app's database
DJANGO_SECRET_KEY	random string (command below)	signs sessions; ALSO encrypts the saved SMTP password - never change it later
DJANGO_DEBUG	false	false = production hardening (HTTPS redirect, secure cookies)
DJANGO_ALLOWED_HOSTS	booking.yourcompany.com	the domain from step 2, no https:// prefix
PUBLIC_BASE_URL	https://booking.yourcompany.com	builds every link inside every email

```
# generate the secret key (any machine with Python):  
python -c "import secrets; print(secrets.token_urlsafe(48))"
```

DO NOT put SMTP settings in the environment

Email credentials belong on the in-app Settings screen (step 8), where the password is encrypted at rest and survives redeloys. Env-var SMTP is a dev fallback only.

5 Add the domain + TLS certificate

Dokploy resource -> **Domains** -> **Add domain** -> **booking.yourcompany.com**, service **web**, port **8000**. Issue the Let's Encrypt certificate and keep the HTTPS redirect on.

Redeploy after adding the domain - domains are applied as Traefik labels and need one extra deploy to take effect.

6 Deploy and watch the build

Click **Deploy**. First build takes a few minutes. On every boot the web container automatically runs **migrate** and **collectstatic**, then starts gunicorn; the scheduler starts once web is healthy. When the web service shows **healthy**, open **https://booking.yourcompany.com/health/** - it must answer with {"status": "ok"}.

FIRST LOGIN ON PRODUCTION

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Create the first admin account

Production starts with an **empty database** - your local logins do not exist there. Dokploy -> web service -> **Terminal**, then:

```
python manage.py createsuperuser
```

Choose a username, **your real email address** (the test-email button sends there) and a strong password. Then log in at <https://booking.yourcompany.com/accounts/login/>.

TURNING ON REAL EMAIL (SMTP)

Everything outbound - booking confirmations, reminders, cancellations, admin welcome mails, password resets - flows through one SMTP mailbox you configure once on the **Settings screen (/settings/, superuser only)**. Until then, nothing is delivered: the app prints emails to the server console instead.

8 Fill in the Settings screen

Log in as superuser -> **Settings** in the top navigation. Fill in, top to bottom:

Field	What to enter	Example
Company name	branding shown in emails + footer	TravelDoor
Public base URL	the production address (email links)	https://booking.yourcompany.com
From name / From address	who every email is from	TravelDoor Connect / bookings@yourcompany.com
SMTP server	your mail provider's server	smtp.gmail.com
Port + encryption	587 + STARTTLS or 465 + SSL (pick ONE)	587, STARTTLS on, SSL off
SMTP username	usually the full mailbox address	bookings@yourcompany.com
SMTP password	APP password for Gmail / M365, not the login password	(hidden after save)

Save. Changes apply immediately - no restart, no redeploy. The password is stored encrypted; leaving the field blank keeps the saved one.

Mail provider cheat sheet

Provider	SMTP server	Port / encryption	Password to use
Gmail / Google Workspace	smtp.gmail.com	587 STARTTLS (or 465 SSL)	App Password (needs 2-Step Verification)
Microsoft 365 / Outlook	smtp.office365.com	587 STARTTLS	App Password
cPanel / company mail	mail.yourcompany.com	587 STARTTLS (or 465 SSL)	mailbox password

9 Prove it works - Send test email

Dashboard (/) -> **Send test email** button (bottom of the status strip). It sends to the email on YOUR admin account and reports the raw SMTP error on failure - that message is usually the whole diagnosis.

Reminders and automatic retries also need the **scheduler** container running - the dashboard's "background jobs" line shows its last tick.

EMAILS GO TO SPAM?

Set SPF, DKIM and DMARC DNS records for your domain, and make the From address belong to the same domain you authenticate the mailbox with. Free Gmail relays ~500 recipients/day.

GO-LIVE CHECKLIST

[] `https://booking.yourcompany.com/health/ answers {"status": "ok"}`

- [] Login works; HTTP redirects to HTTPS automatically
- [] Send test email arrives in your inbox
- [] A test event is created, published, and books end-to-end
- [] Confirmation email arrives; manage link starts with <https://booking.yourcompany.com/>
- [] Reschedule + cancel from the manage link both work
- [] Dashboard shows a recent background-jobs tick (scheduler alive)
- [] "Forgot password?" on the login page delivers a reset link

TROUBLESHOOTING QUICK TABLE

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Test email: (535, authentication)	wrong SMTP user/password; Gmail needs an App Password	re-enter credentials in /settings/
Test email hangs, then times out	port/encryption mismatch	587 = STARTTLS on; 465 = SSL on (never both)
Bad gateway / DisallowedHost page	DJANGO_ALLOWED_HOSTS missing the domain	add the domain, redeploy
CSRF error when booking	PUBLIC_BASE_URL differs from the browser address	exact https:// URL, no trailing slash
Redirect loop over http	DJANGO_DEBUG=false forces HTTPS	use the https:// URL
Reminders never arrive	scheduler stopped or SMTP unset	check scheduler logs; heartbeat on dashboard
Saved SMTP password gone	DJANGO_SECRET_KEY was changed (by design)	re-enter the password in /settings/
migrate crashes on boot	DATABASE_URL contains < > placeholders or quotes	paste the raw internal URL